CRIMINALIZING REPORTING

Belarus v. Marina Zolotova

9 October 2026

CASE FOLLOW-UP REPORT

Procedural developments and verified outcomes

Independent research based on user-supplied TrialWatch materials

ABOUT THIS UPDATE

This independent research update follows the user-supplied TrialWatch material. It is not issued by the Clooney Foundation for Justice, TrialWatch, or the original authors. The earlier report supplies the historical baseline; later developments are supported by the sources cited here.

Jurisdiction	Belarus
Original report	July 2019
Dated update covered	16 September 2026
Research cutoff	9 October 2026
Historical assessment	TrialWatch grade C (original report only)

SCOPE AND METHOD

Research considered public court records, enacted legislation, lawyers and subjects, press-freedom organizations, United Nations materials and attributable reporting available through 9 October 2026. Publication dates and event dates are distinguished. Where judgments or current custody records could not be obtained, the conclusion is expressly qualified. No direct interviews or new trial monitoring were conducted for this update.

An acquittal, quashing order, pardon, sentence completion, bail decision and custody transfer have different legal effects. A reported intention to litigate is separated from an actual filing. Unresolved questions are listed below. Historical TrialWatch grades retain their original attribution; this update does not assign a new grade.

CONTENTS

Executive Summary

Background and Procedural History

Subsequent Developments

Legal and Procedural Assessment

Conclusion and Outstanding Records

Sources and References

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

LATEST VERIFIED POSITION

Pardoned and released in December 2025; living in exile in 2026

Latest related event is the release of later TUT.BY co-defendant Liudmila Chekina on 16 September 2026, not a new disposition for Zolotova. Zolotova's latest substantive personal account located is dated 7 August 2026. Her pardon and release do not establish that either conviction was overturned.

Marina Zolotova, also transliterated Maryna Zolatava, was pardoned and released on 13 December 2025 after more than four years in custody in the later TUT.BY prosecution. In an account published by RSF Switzerland on 7 August 2026, she described life in exile in Poland and reunion with her family. [3] [4]

The latest related development verified before the cutoff is CPJ's 16 September 2026 confirmation that TUT.BY director and co-defendant Liudmila Chekina was also released. This does not alter the distinction between Zolotova's 2019 fine-only prosecution and the separate 2023 prison sentence. [5] [1] [2]

1. User-supplied original report, July 2019.
2. Committee to Protect Journalists, 17 March 2023. Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava sentenc...
3. Committee to Protect Journalists, 15 December 2025. Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava release...
4. Reporters Without Borders Switz..., 7 August 2026. Free, but not at home: Belarusian journalist...
5. Committee to Protect Journalists, 16 September 2026. CPJ welcomes release of three journalists in...

BACKGROUND AND PROCEDURAL HISTORY

The July 2019 report concerned access by TUT.BY staff to material from the state-owned BeLTA news agency using shared subscription credentials. BeLTA temporarily restricted access to some stories before making them generally available. Zolotova, TUT.BY's editor-in-chief, was prosecuted for inaction by an official, based on an alleged failure to prevent the practice. Other people initially investigated were not tried alongside her. After a two-week trial in February 2019, she was convicted and fined rather than sentenced to imprisonment. [1]

ABA Center for Human Rights staff, acting as TrialWatch experts, assigned a C. The report considered the conduct of the trial largely fair but identified concerns about the purpose of singling out Zolotova and the reliability of pretrial statements. It could not assess a published reasoned judgment at the time. This historical report did not address the later raid on TUT.BY, the subsequent detention, or the closed national-security prosecution. [1]

KEY PROCEDURAL DATES

July 2019	Original TrialWatch report published on the fine-only BeLTA-related prosecution. [1]
May 2021	Zolotova arrested in the later investigation involving TUT.BY. [2]
17 March 2023	Minsk court imposed a twelve-year prison sentence in the separate later case. [2]
13 December 2025	Zolotova released among prisoners pardoned following negotiations with the United States. [3]
7 August 2026	RSF Switzerland published her account of exile, protection in Poland and family reunion. [4]
16 September 2026	CPJ confirmed release of later TUT.BY co-defendant Liudmila Chekina. [5]

1. User-supplied original report, July 2019.
2. Committee to Protect Journalists, 17 March 2023. Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava sentenc...
3. Committee to Protect Journalists, 15 December 2025. Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava release...
4. Reporters Without Borders Switz..., 7 August 2026. Free, but not at home: Belarusian journalist...
5. Committee to Protect Journalists, 16 September 2026. CPJ welcomes release of three journalists in...

SUBSEQUENT DEVELOPMENTS

Zolotova was arrested in May 2021, well after the monitored case. On 17 March 2023, CPJ reported a twelve-year sentence for inciting hatred and distributing calls aimed at harming national security following a closed trial. The initial tax-evasion allegation against her had been dropped. It is therefore inaccurate to describe her twelve-year sentence as either punishment for the 2019 BeLTA charge or a tax-evasion conviction. [2]

CPJ's 15 December 2025 report confirmed that the release had occurred on 13 December, not merely that it was expected. It reported presidential pardons for the released group and placed Zolotova among them. CPJ welcomed her release while maintaining that her imprisonment was unjust. Its account supplies evidence of actual liberty from prison; it does not supply a judgment reversing the conviction. [3]

In the RSF Switzerland account, Zolotova described being free since December but unable to return to her previous home. She explained the transfer through Ukraine into the European Union, obtaining international protection in Poland and reuniting with her family. This first-person account materially updates the immediate release announcement: it documents her circumstances months later rather than assuming that a pardon restored residence, work and family life in Belarus. [4]

Chekina's situation must be dated separately. Although she remained imprisoned when the August account appeared, CPJ reported her release on 16 September among three freed journalists. The later event supersedes earlier descriptions of that co-defendant's custody. It should not be recast as a September release for Zolotova herself or as termination of the TUT.BY prosecution. [5]

LEGAL AND PROCEDURAL ASSESSMENT

The following assessment draws inferences from the cited record. It does not represent a new court finding or TrialWatch grade.

one independent follow-up report can preserve the 2019 trial as its baseline while presenting the later prosecution as a distinct procedural history. Merging the two would obscure the different allegations, sanctions and evidentiary records, and would wrongly extend TrialWatch's monitoring to a closed trial it did not observe. [1] [2]

release and exile change the practical harm of imprisonment but do not answer the legality of the convictions. The absence of a verified quashing judgment is an evidentiary limit, not proof that every possible challenge failed. Chekina's later release updates a companion defendant's status without establishing Zolotova's legal rehabilitation. [3] [4] [5]

1. User-supplied original report, July 2019.
2. Committee to Protect Journalists, 17 March 2023. Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava sentenc...
3. Committee to Protect Journalists, 15 December 2025. Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava release...
4. Reporters Without Borders Switz..., 7 August 2026. Free, but not at home: Belarusian journalist...
5. Committee to Protect Journalists, 16 September 2026. CPJ welcomes release of three journalists in...

CONCLUSION AND OUTSTANDING RECORDS

The verified outcome is freedom from imprisonment followed by documented life in exile, not an acquittal. The original C remains an attributed historical assessment of the 2019 proceedings; the later twelve-year sentence and presidential pardon require their own clearly separated account.

RECORDS NOT VERIFIED

1. Published reasoned judgment and any appeal outcome in the 2019 BeLTA-related case.

2. Full judgment and verified completed appeal or review in the separate 2023 prosecution; a reported intention to appeal is insufficient.

3. Individual pardon instrument and its effects on convictions, civil disabilities, travel documents and return rights.

4. Any post-August 2026 substantive update on Zolotova's own legal status, distinct from Chekina's September release.

Failure to locate an update leaves a gap in the available evidence; it does not establish that no later proceeding or change occurred. Any present-status claim should be read with the dated scope stated in the executive summary.

SOURCES AND REFERENCES

Numbered references correspond to superscript citations and page notes. Web sources were consulted for this research through 9 October 2026. Original reports are local user-supplied files. Each link opens the cited source.

1. **Original user-supplied report on Belarus v. Marina Zolotova**
TrialWatch / original report authors. July 2019.
Local PDF: monitoring-of-the-trial-of-marina-zolotova.pdf
Coverage: Historical case baseline and original assessment

2. **Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava sentenced to 12 years in prison, Valeryia Kastsiuhova to 10 years**
Committee to Protect Journalists. 17 March 2023.
Read source at cpj.org
Coverage: Later arrest and closed prosecution; twelve-year sentence; initial tax allegation dropped

3. **Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava released after serving over 4 years in prison**
Committee to Protect Journalists. 15 December 2025.
Read source at cpj.org
Coverage: Actual release on 13 December 2025 and presidential pardon

4. **Free, but not at home: Belarusian journalist Maryna Zolatava on her life in exile**
Reporters Without Borders Switzerland. 7 August 2026.
Read source at rsf-ch.ch
Coverage: Post-release transfer; protection in Poland; family reunion; continued exile

5. **CPJ welcomes release of three journalists in Belarus**
Committee to Protect Journalists. 16 September 2026.
Read source at cpj.org
Coverage: Later release of co-defendant Liudmila Chekina, not a new Zolotova release